The 2027 fellowship & contest calendar

When the programs and competitions that actually launch careers open for submissions, month by month. Windows are based on each program's 2026 cycle and shift slightly every year, so confirm exact dates and fees on the official site before you apply.

January

Sundance Screenwriters Lab takes place —
Lab in session; next application opens late March

February

CineStory Feature Retreat & Fellowship opens — $50–$95
Feb to early July · $10K fellowship + mentorship

SFFILM Sloan Science in Cinema Fellowship opens — $30–$50
Feb to late May · $35K for science-themed projects

The Writers Lab (NYWIFT) opens — See site
Feb to April · women & nonbinary writers 40+

March

Austin Film Festival Script Competition opens — $50–$90
Late March to late May · features, pilots, shorts

Final Draft Big Break opens — $45–$85
Late March to late June · $10K grand prizes

Slamdance Screenplay Competition opens — $50–$120
Mid-March to early August · reader notes for all

Sundance Screenwriters Lab application opens — Fee
Late March to late April (2028 Lab cycle)

April

Paramount Writers Mentoring Program — Free
April 1 to May 1 · TV, 8-month mentorship

May

Disney Entertainment TV Writing Program — Free
Early May to June 1 · paid staff job, two pilots

NBC TV Writers Program — Free
Historically May · check for next intake

Film Independent Project Involve opens — Fee
Mid-May to mid-July · film & TV

Script Pipeline final deadlines — $45–$75
Around May · Screenwriting & TV contests

June

Academy Nicholl Fellowships: Black List portal opens — Fee
Early June, about 4 weeks or until capped · up to five $35K fellowships

Academy Nicholl Fellowships: WGF portal opens — $100–$120
Late June, about 4 weeks or until capped

Film Independent Screenwriting Lab opens — Fee
Late June to Aug 31 · features

BlueCat Screenplay Competition opens — $59–$95
Late June to early November · written notes for all

July

Sundance Episodic Lab opens — $50
Mid-July to late August · pilots, international

Berlinale Talents opens — €10–€15
July to early September · emerging film & TV creatives

August

CineStory TV Retreat & Fellowship opens — $50–$95
August to mid-December · pilots

Film Independent Screenwriting Lab closes — —
August 31

September

Channel 4 4Screenwriting (UK) — Free
Late September to early October · paid course

October

Women in Film x Black List Episodic Lab — $40
October 1 to early November · LA-based

Stowe Story Labs early deadline — See site
Early October, then rolling into spring

CAPE New Writers Fellowship — See site
Applications typically open in the fall

November

BBC Writers Open Call (UK) — Free
November to early December · unsolicited scripts

TorinoFilmLab calls — See site
November to December · European labs

December

Sundance Native Lab — Free
December 1 to 22 · Indigenous writers, film or TV

Sundance Episodic Sloan Grant — Waiver available
Early December · science-themed series

Script Pipeline pre-registration — Reduced
Late December for next year’s contests

> **Before you pay any entry fee:** grade your draft against the Nicholl scoring rubric (free on oscars.org), and skip any contest that can’t name past winners who got real work from it. Coverfly, ScreenCraft, WeScreenplay, The Script Lab and the Tracking Board have all shut down.
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> **Want a professional read before you submit?** Feature notes $600 · TV pilot notes $400 · screenwritingconsultant.com/#services